INSIDE THE INDUSTRY

AGENTS BLAME INVENTORY. NAR'S OWN DATA DISAGREES.

Affordability outranks it as the top buyer constraint, and it isn't close.

D.J. Paris
Keeping It Real Podcast

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27 PERCENT SAY AFFORDABILITY. ONLY 12 BLAME INVENTORY.

NAR asked its own members what's actually stopping buyers from closing. This was the answer.

THE REAL SPLIT ISN'T RATES. IT'S WHO ALREADY HAS EQUITY.

NAR's 2026 Member Profile asked its own brokerage specialists to name the single biggest factor keeping their clients from completing a purchase. Housing affordability led by a wide margin at 27 percent, more than double lack of inventory at 12 percent and "difficulty finding the right property" at 11 percent. NAR deputy chief economist Jessica Lautz put the pattern behind the number plainly: the market is "sharply divided between repeat buyers with housing equity who can move with relative ease and first-time buyers who are struggling to save for a down payment." The obstacle agents spend the most time managing on a showing schedule is not the one their own membership says is actually keeping deals from closing.

CHANGE THE BUYER CONSULTATION THIS WEEK:

1. **Open with the down payment gap, not the search criteria.**
   Ask what they have saved and what assistance programs exist for the gap before you tour a single property.

2. **Bring equity into the conversation on both sides of a deal.**
   A move-up buyer's equity is the lever a first-time buyer doesn't have, and a seller should hear that context too.

3. **Put financing options on the table before the showing schedule.**
   NAR's own members say money, not the search, is what actually stalls the sale.

THE TAKEAWAY

YOUR BUYERS AREN'T STUCK ON CHOICE. THEY'RE STUCK ON CASH.

Start the conversation there and the search gets easier.

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